



outfield turn soggy from inside the pavilion.

With the Super Soppers pressed into service, the game eventually resumed. CSG's bowlers exploited the conditions well and restricted SMP to 156/7 — slightly below par given the venue's short boundaries.

CSG, the most successful team in the league's history, looked assured in the chase. But midway through the ninth over, with the score at 71/3, the match was disrupted again — this time, not by rain, but by an unexpected swarm of winged insects that descended upon the stadium.

The acrid smoke of burning neem leaves wafted through the air in an attempt to repel the bugs, but they lingered stubbornly. Despite the infestation, officials pressed on with reduced overs.

Players struggled to focus, swatting away insects between deliveries, while the crowd shared in their discomfort.

Eventually, Vijay Shankar and Narayan Jagadeesan guided CSG home, preserving their team's unbeaten league record.

For the Diary, which had clocked in around 5 a.m., the day didn't end until 2 the next morning. A 21-hour TNPL shift was perhaps not the kind of "special" the diary had imagined when signing up for sports journalism.

Nigamanth P

Balancing act

Despite Saurashtra's dominance in red-ball cricket, its T20 record remains underwhelming. The team has yet to lift the Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy, and representation in the Indian Premier League has been thin. In 2025, only Chetan Sakariya (**pic, below**) and Jaydev Unadkat featured in the IPL, while players like Harvik Desai and Prerak Mankad, once seen as promising T20 prospects, couldn't cement their places.

In this context, the launch of the Saurashtra Pro T20 League has served dual purposes — as a platform for local players and as a competitive tournament that prioritised balance between bat and ball. Hosted entirely at Rajkot's Niranjan Shah Stadium — notorious for its flat, batter-friendly surfaces — the league marked a conscious shift.

"The tournament is long. Each team plays eight games. Only three black-soil pitches have been used. They've been prepared to last the tournament,"

Buzzkill: From rain delays to insect swarms, the TNPL match in Natham tested more than just cricketing skills.

NIGAMANTH P

explained Sakariya.

Rajkot's reputation precedes it: in four ODIs played here, 300-plus totals were breached thrice, and in T20Is, the average first-innings score is 187. But in the Pro League, that number came down to 165. Teams even defended totals under 140 on three occasions.

Unseasonal rain towards the end of the tournament added a layer of unpredictability, injecting just enough moisture to help bowlers stay relevant. In the final, Anmol Kings Halar was dismissed for 142, yet managed to push JMD Kutch Riders deep into the 17th over.

"There was help for bowlers early on, but later the tracks eased out — which actually made matches more competitive," said Aryan Sorath Lions' Arpit Vasavada. A first step, perhaps, but the league has shown that Saurashtra's T20 future might just be worth investing in.

Abhishek Saini

